

Summary of key findings

FBDG implementation in Badulla area

According to recent literature and statistical reports, the nutrition and food security situation in Badulla District has shown both improvements and new challenges compared to the 2009 Nutrition and Food Security Survey. However, after the impact of Cyclone Dithwa (2025), vulnerabilities related to food security, agriculture, displacement, and nutrition have increased again, especially among low-income rural and estate communities.

Current nutrition situation in Badulla district

Recent national nutrition statistics from 2024 show that child malnutrition still remains a serious concern in Sri Lanka, including in Badulla District.

According to the 2024 National Nutrition Month Report, Badulla recorded the second-highest prevalence of underweight children under five years in the country at 14.1%. Although there was a slight improvement nationally compared to 2023, the district still remains nutritionally vulnerable <https://ceylontoday.lk/2024/10/12/infant-nutrition-improves-in-2024-compared-to-2023>

Compared with the 2009 survey findings:

<https://www.mri.gov.lk/assets/Nutrition/2009-Nutrition-food-Security-Survey-Badulla-.pdf>

- ✓ Underweight among children under five reduced from 23.0% in 2009 to around 14.1% in 2024
- ✓ Wasting has also slightly declined nationally
- ✓ However, chronic undernutrition and dietary inadequacy still persist among vulnerable groups.

Recent reports also highlight continuing:

- ✓ Protein deficiency
- ✓ Poor dietary diversity
- ✓ Micronutrient deficiencies
- ✓ Economic barriers to healthy diets in Uva Province and Badulla.

<https://www.wvi.org/newsroom/global-hunger-crisis/taking-nutrition-its-roots>

Situation after cyclone Dithwa (2025–2026)

The situation worsened after Cyclone Dithwa, which severely affected agricultural and estate-based livelihoods in Badulla District.

The United Nations Situation Report (2026) stated that:

- ✓ Thousands of families in Badulla were displaced
- ✓ Relief centres were established in the district
- ✓ More than 1,100 families remained in temporary shelters months after the disaster
- ✓ Food access and livelihood recovery became major concerns.

<https://srilanka.un.org/en/310507-cyclone-ditwah-situation-report-20-february-2026>

Badulla is one of Sri Lanka's major vegetable-producing districts. Cyclone Dithwa caused:

- ✓ Destruction of vegetable cultivation
- ✓ Reduced food production
- ✓ Income loss among farming families
- ✓ Increased risk of household food insecurity.

FAO and the Australian Government launched a USD 1.4 million agricultural recovery programme specifically targeting Badulla and Nuwara Eliya to restore food production systems after the cyclone.

<https://english.newsfirst.lk/2026/05/05/australia-fao-and-sri-lanka-launch-usd-1-4-million-recovery-drive-for-cyclone-hit-vegetable-farmers>

Current evidence suggests that food insecurity in Badulla remains strongly associated with:

- ✓ Poverty
- ✓ Dependence on agriculture
- ✓ Climate-related disasters
- ✓ Rising food prices
- ✓ Limited dietary diversity

Community reports and nutrition programmes in Badulla also show that:

- ✓ Children in rural and estate communities continue to experience malnutrition and protein deficiency
- ✓ School feeding and preschool meal programmes have improved attendance and dietary intake among children
- ✓ Estate sector women remain highly vulnerable to anaemia and undernutrition.

<https://etp-global.org/our-initiatives/holistic-nutrition-improvement-programme>

Water, Sanitation, and Health Services

Compared to 2009, access to sanitation and healthcare services has improved in Badulla due to:

- ✓ Expanded maternal and child health programmes
- ✓ Nutrition counselling services
- ✓ Hospital nutrition units
- ✓ Community-level interventions.

<https://thbadulla.health.gov.lk/?portfolio=department-of-medical-nutrition>

However, post-disaster conditions after Dithwa created temporary challenges in:

- ✓ Safe water access
- ✓ Sanitation in relief centres
- ✓ Food storage and hygiene
- ✓ Mental health and psychosocial wellbeing

Recent evidence shows that many of these issues still continue today, although some indicators have improved.

After Dithwa, the district experienced a setback in food security and livelihoods, especially among farming and estate communities. Recovery programmes are ongoing, but literature suggests that long-term improvement will require:

- ✓ Strengthened food security programmes
- ✓ Climate-resilient agriculture
- ✓ Nutrition education using FBDG
- ✓ Better income generation opportunities
- ✓ Improved maternal and child nutrition interventions.

Impact of Cyclone Dithwa

Cyclone Dithwa severely affected Badulla because the district heavily depends on agriculture and estate livelihoods.

The cyclone caused:

- ✓ crop destruction
- ✓ landslides

- ✓ displacement
- ✓ loss of income
- ✓ food shortages
- ✓ damage to roads and markets
- ✓ increased food prices

Thousands of people in Badulla were displaced, and many families are still recovering economically.

<https://srilanka.un.org/en/310507-cyclone-ditwah-situation-report-20-february-2026>

As a result:

- ✓ families may prioritize cheap filling foods instead of nutritious foods
- ✓ dietary diversity becomes lower
- ✓ mothers and children become more nutritionally vulnerable
- ✓ people may have low affordability to practice healthy eating

Why FBDG is important for Badulla

The FBDGs are highly relevant after Dithwa because it promotes:

- ✓ balanced low-cost meals
- ✓ home gardening
- ✓ local food utilization
- ✓ healthier cooking methods
- ✓ reduction of ultra-processed foods

In post-disaster settings, FBDGs can help communities:

- ✓ improve nutrition even with limited resources
- ✓ reduce malnutrition among children
- ✓ improve maternal nutrition
- ✓ strengthen immunity
- ✓ rebuild healthier food systems

How we can do that?

1. Use community-based nutrition education

Rather than conducting only lectures, use:

- ✓ group discussions
- ✓ demonstrations
- ✓ practical sessions
- ✓ photovoice activities
- ✓ visual food plate models

2. Focus on affordable local foods

After Dithwa, affordability is a major issue.

Therefore, sessions should focus on:

- ✓ low-cost nutritious foods,
- ✓ locally available foods,
- ✓ seasonal vegetables,
- ✓ home gardening.

It is important to explain that healthy eating does not necessarily mean expensive food.

Since many communities are recovering from disaster impacts, nutrition programmes should connect with livelihood recovery, home gardening, school nutrition, food preservation and climate-resilient agriculture.

For that we can collaborate with Public Health Midwives, agriculture officers, Samurdhi/ Aswesuma officers, NGOs, schools and disaster recovery programmes.